

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Government and Public Administration English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For public administrators, agency program managers, policy analysts, procurement staff, constituent-service teams, grants managers, and interagency coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

03 Procurement and Vendor Selection

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

05 Interagency Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

06 Constituent Services and Escalation

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

07 Transparency, Records, and Ethics

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Policy Implementation and Program Rules

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A resident mistakes draft eligibility guidance for a final rule. The office has published current guidance and a separate proposal.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: policy, eligibility, implementation, public guidance.

Model response

The proposal is under review; the current published guidance remains the reference for today's process. Let me show you the distinction and where official updates will appear.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. The proposal is not current eligibility guidance - The lesson's office has current guidance and a separate proposal; a constituent-facing team needs to explain the difference after a resident confuses them.
2. An effective date and a training date - Separate fictional case: an office's approved service procedure begins on Monday; staff training occurred last Thursday. A supervisor confuses the training date with implementation.

3. Meeting a condition versus receiving a decision - Separate fictional case: a fictional program's guidance lists several eligibility conditions, and a service team is discussing a caller who mentions only one condition.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A summary leaflet and the full guidance

In a fictional program, a short leaflet omits a condition that appears in the current full guidance. No decision has been made on a caller's case. Discuss how the service team should explain the difference and seek correction of the leaflet.

Role A: You are the service supervisor. Explain why a shortened leaflet is not an individual eligibility decision.

Role B: You are the policy coordinator. Clarify the authoritative internal source and arrange review of the omission.

Possible opening: The leaflet is a summary, and it omits a condition that appears in the current full guidance.

Success checks

- Explain summary guidance versus an individual decision.
- Acknowledge the confusing omission without inventing a remedy.
- Agree an authorized clarification and leaflet-review next step.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to promise approval because the caller relied on the leaflet.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

At a public meeting, two speakers use most of the time and several people have not been heard. The meeting has an announced participation process.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: public comment, stakeholder, public record, facilitation.

Model response

Let's return to the announced speaking process so more people can contribute. I'll summarize the points raised and invite the next speaker, while keeping the record clear about what remains unresolved.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Return to the announced participation process - At the lesson's public meeting, two speakers have used most of the time and several participants remain unheard; an announced participation process exists.

2. Remote participants have lost the audio - Separate fictional case: a hybrid consultation meeting has remote participants, but they report missing the last explanation of two service options. No decision has been taken.

3. A technical answer does not settle a value question - Separate fictional case: a public workshop compares longer library hours with more mobile visits; the cost briefing is complete, but access advocates have not yet spoken.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A correction to the consultation summary

At a fictional transport consultation, the draft spoken summary says all participants prefer option A. The clerk's notes show one participant supported B and another asked for more information. Reopen the summary briefly and agree accurate wording.

Role A: You are the facilitator. Invite correction without restarting the entire debate.

Role B: You are the committee clerk. State the recorded differences and distinguish them from a formal decision.

Possible opening: Before we close, I need to correct the impression that everyone supported option A.

Success checks

- Include the differing recorded views.
- Distinguish consultation input from a formal decision.
- Close with an accurate summary and identify who will confirm the next decision-process step.

Add a complication: The meeting sponsor asks you to describe the discussion as unanimous for simplicity.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Procurement and Vendor Selection

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A procurement evaluation note uses "best value" without linking the judgment to published evaluation criteria.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: RFP, evaluation criteria, bidder, procurement rule.

Model response

Which stated criteria support that assessment? Please connect the evidence to those criteria so the review explains the basis for the judgment rather than relying on a general label.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. What does best value refer to? - The lesson's procurement evaluation note says best value without connecting that judgment to the published evaluation criteria.
2. An optional feature in the scoring discussion - Separate fictional case: a fictional RFP scores response time and implementation support; a panel member wants to award points for a dashboard feature not listed in those criteria.

3. A quote with unclear installation scope - Separate fictional case: an evaluator compares two equipment bids; one clearly includes installation, while the other does not state whether installation is included.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two versions of an evaluation sheet

A fictional panel has two evaluation-sheet versions with different criterion labels. The procurement officer has not confirmed which version applies. Discuss how to clarify the approved sheet before scoring continues.

Role A: You are the panel coordinator. Identify the version mismatch and ask for confirmation.

Role B: You are the procurement officer. Request both versions and their sources without guessing which is authoritative.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which evaluation-sheet version applies? The two copies use different criterion labels.

Success checks

- Identify the version ambiguity specifically.
- Avoid selecting criteria based on a preferred result.
- Agree an authorized version check before scoring resumes.

Add a complication: A panel member wants to use whichever sheet gives their preferred bidder the higher score.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A grant report contains a total expenditure figure but lacks the requested supporting categories.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: grant, subrecipient, allowable cost, reporting.

Model response

Could you provide the category breakdown and supporting references required for this report? If an item is unresolved, please identify it so the grants team can explain the next step.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. The total needs supporting categories - The lesson's grant report contains total expenditure but omits the supporting categories requested for reporting.
2. A subrecipient's missing reporting period - Separate fictional case: a subrecipient submits a cost schedule labeled quarter total without dates; the grant team needs the April-through-June reporting period.

3. An invoice without the grant reference - Separate fictional case: a fictional grant report includes an invoice for shared training, but no allocation record links the charge to this grant.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An undated exchange-rate calculation

A fictional grant schedule converts a supplier payment into reporting currency, but the conversion date and rate source are missing. The required grant method has not been checked. Request the information needed for review without choosing a rate yourself.

Role A: You are the grant reviewer. Ask for the method, date, and source supporting the conversion.

Role B: You are the subrecipient accountant. Explain what you must verify and offer a realistic response check.

Possible opening: Could you provide the conversion date and rate source so we can check this amount against the grant's reporting method?

Success checks

- Request the missing calculation evidence precisely.
- Do not invent the grant's required conversion method.
- Agree ownership and timing for the clarification.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests using today's rate because it is easiest to find.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Interagency Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

Two agencies are coordinating a service request. Each assumes the other will contact the resident.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: jurisdiction, memorandum of understanding, data sharing, owner.

Model response

Could we confirm which agency will make the next contact and by when? I'll record that responsibility and the permitted information-sharing route so the resident receives a coordinated response.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Name the resident-contact owner - The lesson's two agencies each assume the other will contact the resident about a coordinated service request.

2. A transfer that has not been accepted - Separate fictional case: an agency emailed a referral to a partner office; the partner's automatic receipt arrived, but no case owner has acknowledged acceptance.

3. Two tasks, two agency owners - Separate fictional case: a coordinated community-center reopening requires a facilities inspection and a public-information update; the facilities agency owns inspection, and the service agency owns communications.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A liaison changes during a referral

In a fictional interagency case, the original partner liaison has moved roles. A referral is still pending, and a replacement contact has been named but has not acknowledged the action. Conduct a handoff without treating the replacement's name as acceptance.

Role A: You are the sending liaison. Summarize the pending action using the existing case reference.

Role B: You are the receiving coordinator. Confirm what you can accept and identify any authority question.

Possible opening: This referral still needs an acknowledged owner following the liaison change.

Success checks

- State the pending action rather than merely transfer a name.
- Seek explicit responsibility acknowledgment.
- Keep personal information within the agreed sharing process.

Add a complication: The old liaison's automated reply says all matters are now with the replacement.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Constituent Services and Escalation

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A resident has been redirected between offices without an explanation of who can address the issue.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: constituent, casework, appeal, authority.

Model response

I'm sorry you have been redirected without a clear explanation. Let me identify the office with the relevant authority and confirm the next contact rather than send you on without that information.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. C - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. B - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. Repairing an unexplained referral loop - The lesson's resident has been redirected repeatedly; a constituent-services supervisor coaches the officer responsible for the next response.
2. A receipt letter mistaken for approval - Separate fictional case: a constituent-services email called an application accepted when it had only been received; the decision remains pending.

3. The wrong office was named in a callback - Separate fictional case: a callback note named the licensing desk for a fee-query case; the service team has since confirmed the finance inquiry desk is the appropriate contact, but no outcome is known.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A callback commitment was missed

A fictional casework office promised a callback on Tuesday but did not make it. It is now Wednesday, and the underlying case still has no decision. Discuss an apology and a realistic communication arrangement without inventing a case outcome.

Role A: You are the casework officer. Acknowledge the missed callback and distinguish it from the pending decision.

Role B: You are the service supervisor. Ask what contact you can genuinely arrange now.

Possible opening: We missed the callback we promised, and I need to acknowledge that separately from the pending case decision.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the missed communication clearly.
- Avoid claiming decision authority or a guaranteed outcome.
- Agree a feasible next contact and its limited purpose.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests promising approval to offset the service failure.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Transparency, Records, and Ethics

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A records request involves material that may require review for an exemption. An initial note says all material will automatically be released.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: public records, exemption, conflict of interest, ethics.

Model response

The request needs review under the applicable records process. I'll avoid promising a release decision before that review and explain how the office will communicate the outcome.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Located records are not cleared records - The lesson's public-records request may involve material requiring exemption review; an initial note incorrectly promises automatic release of everything.

2. A declared connection is not a misconduct finding - Separate fictional case: a committee member discloses a prior professional connection with a bidder; the ethics review has not assessed it.

3. A search result does not establish completeness - Separate fictional case: a records search returned files from the shared drive, but archived email has not yet been searched.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A missing attachment in a public record

A fictional records response identifies an email referring to an attachment, but the attachment has not been located. No exemption decision concerns that attachment yet. Discuss how to describe the gap and the next search step.

Role A: You are the records coordinator. State what has been found and what remains missing.

Role B: You are the department liaison. Challenge whether missing means deliberately withheld.

Possible opening: We located the email, but its referenced attachment has not yet been found.

Success checks

- Distinguish not located from withheld after review.
- Avoid claims about motive or exemption status.
- Agree the next authorized search or clarification step.

Add a complication: Someone wants to label the attachment exempt to explain its absence.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A budget proposal lists activities delivered but does not show the intended public outcomes.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: appropriation, outcome measure, equity, public value.

Model response

The activity count tells us what was delivered. We also need to explain the intended outcome and how it will be assessed. I'll connect the spending request to that public-purpose question.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Activities delivered versus public outcomes - The lesson's budget proposal lists delivered activities but does not show the intended public outcomes.

2. More appointments, unchanged waiting time - Separate fictional case: a service office delivered 1,200 appointments this quarter, up from 1,000, while measured average waiting time remained ten days.

3. A citywide average hides access questions - Separate fictional case: a fictional digital-service pilot reports a citywide completion rate but has not examined outcomes for people using assisted access.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Training staff versus reducing errors

A fictional office trained forty staff to reduce application-processing errors. Training attendance is recorded, but before-and-after error rates are unavailable. Explain the distinction during a budget conversation and agree a suitable evidence question.

Role A: You are the program manager. State the training output and intended outcome separately.

Role B: You are the budget reviewer. Ask what would show whether processing improved.

Possible opening: Forty staff attended training, but we have not yet measured whether processing errors decreased.

Success checks

- Distinguish attendance from an achieved service outcome.
- Explain an outcome measure in everyday language.
- Agree what comparable evidence is needed without inventing results.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to label all forty attendees as forty demonstrated service improvements.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.